

My worst (digital) fears...



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“Wanna know what I fear the most? It's 2 AM on Saturday and I'm deeply immersed in some game on my PS4 (Witcher 3, for instance). I've waited all week to finally play uninterrupted for hours on end. Just as my grin spreads from ear to ear, and I clock one hour of gameplay, suddenly there's a power cut.”

All of us who aren't invincible – Chuck Norris, I'm looking at you – harbour some or the other legitimate fear in our lifetime. Some of us fear losing control of oneself, while others fear loneliness. Where some harbour fear of heights (myself included), there are quite a few who are afraid of public speaking. These days, the prospect of no 3G connection is fast escalating from cause of frustration to something that's making people a lot more paranoid, fearful even – it's true.

Wanna know what I fear the most? It's 2 AM on Saturday and I'm deeply immersed in some game on my PS4 (Witcher 3, for instance). I've waited all week to finally play uninterrupted for hours on end. Just as my grin spreads from ear to ear, and I clock one hour of gameplay, suddenly there's a power cut. No, no, no, no, not today, not now. I curse loudly. The power doesn't return until Monday morning, as I'm getting dressed to leave for work. Billions of blue blistering boiled and barbecued barnacles!

An entire weekend wasted with no gaming. That's one of my greatest fears.

You know what else I fear? Croaking before witnessing the day when 1Tbps affordable internet becomes a reality in every home in India, including mine. Why? Because I've had pathetic internet speeds throughout my life till now – I just don't know why. Maybe in a previous life I worked for a company that didn't deliver on its claims and promises to valued customers, gathering a lot of bad karma in the process, paying heavily for it in this life.

In my travels abroad, having had the honour of representing Digit in various overseas conferences, I've come to realise the importance of our most valued document as Indians – our passport. Nothing else is respected or recognized when it comes to establishing your identity in a foreign land other than your passport. And getting one in India is akin to going through a special circle of hell altogether. So another one of my fears is that one fine day this passport application process will sort itself out, it will all happen through a click of the button, interviews through video conferencing, remote verification of documents, the whole nine yards... all of this through software and technological innova-

tions, no need to go to Passport Seva Kendra. But I won't be there to witness that day. My luck just gets better and better, doesn't it? Hang on, there's more.

Like the friendly, neighbourhood astrophysicist, Neil Degrasse Tyson, I too harbour the fear of not being alive around the time we finally come in contact with extraterrestrial life. Maybe our “deeply immature” attempts of METI will attract our trigger-happy Overlords to exterminate us in the first place, but hey, I'd still rather die in an alien scourge than some boring “normal” way. How cool would that be?

On a slightly more serious note, though, there are some things that really scare me. Things that are a direct consequence of our digital existence. Like identity theft.

As part of Digital India, a lot of efforts are directed towards centralizing sensitive private documents of citizens in services such as E-lockers, E-signature, linking bank accounts to other integrated government services, and more. Imagine if all of this data is breached? Worse, if all of this data is lost and my identity ceases to exist in the eyes of the government? Colour me pessimistic, but identity theft can be a bad consequence of haphazard digitisation.

Stories of cyberbullying don't seem just sensational anymore, they feel real. Especially with raising a child, making sure they don't fall prey to this menace of our digital society is an increasing fear in my mind of late.

My last and final worry as far as this month's column is concerned is that despite all our technological advancements humanity's going to self-destruct – or send everyone back to the dark ages – through the Great Cyber War that's surely around the corner. Who needs aliens to bring down highly evolved homo sapiens? Sigh.

What are some of your worst digital fears, dear reader? Write to me, I'd love to hear your story. 

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